Former US National Security Advisor Zbigniew Brzezinski had already observed in 2012 that China's remarkable momentum justifies ranking it just below the United States in the international hierarchy. At the time, he further argued that, although a sequential ranking of other major powers beyond the top two would be imprecise at best, any list "has to include Russia, Japan, and India, as well as the EU's informal leaders: Great Britain, Germany, and France."[3] India is not a P-5 country with veto power in the UN Security Council or a member of the exclusive economic club of G7, but its gross domestic product (GDP) surpassed that of France and the United Kingdom in 2019 to become the world's fifth largest economy after the United States, China, Japan, and Germany.[4] In terms of purchasing power parity (PPP) figures, India is already the third largest economy, after China and the United States.[5] In 2018, India had the third largest defence budget in the world, it is adding sea power to its traditional role as a continental power,[6] and, with the commissioning of the nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine *INS Arihant* in August 2016, India is closing in on possessing a fully operational nuclear triad, together with the United States, Russia, and China. India's growing economic and military prowess is increasing its position and ambition as a regional power in South Asia and the wider Indo-Pacific strategic theatre.

Second, since assuming office in 2014, the Modi government has shown that India is now willing to build more comprehensive relations with neighbouring countries, as well as with the great powers.[7] It should be acknowledged that ever since the end of the Cold War, it has been a pan-partisan effort in India to establish greater diplomatic elbow room, engaging with neighbouring countries through initiatives like the Look East (now Act East policy), Look West, or Connect Central Asia, and with other major powers at a bilateral level as well as through multilateral